

7 Methuselah

The oldest man in the Bible, son of Enoch and grandfather of Noah.

Methuselah is famous for one thing: he lived longer than anyone else recorded in Scripture, 969 years. Genesis tells us almost nothing else about him. He was the son of Enoch, who walked with God, and the father of Lamech, who named his son Noah in hope of comfort. So Methuselah stands between two great men of faith. By the numbers in the Hebrew text of Genesis 5, he died in the same year as the flood. Genesis does not say how he died or comment on the timing. His long life is a reminder that even the longest life ends, and that what matters is how our days are spent.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Metushelach</i> . Its meaning is uncertain; "man of the spear" or "man of the dart" are common suggestions
Family	Son of Enoch; father of Lamech, plus other sons and daughters; grandfather of Noah (Genesis 5:21, 25–29)
Lifespan	969 years, the longest recorded in Scripture (Genesis 5:27)
Key people	Enoch, Lamech, Noah
Main passages	Genesis 5:21–27
New Testament	Luke 3:37 ("Mathusala")

"And all the days of Methuselah were nine hundred sixty and nine years: and he died."

Genesis 5:27, KJV

The life of Methuselah

Ages come from Genesis 5 in the Hebrew text. The Greek Septuagint gives different numbers.

Enoch's 65th year	●	Born Enoch fathers Methuselah and walks with God for 300 years afterward. <i>Genesis 5:21-22</i>
Age 187	●	Father of Lamech Methuselah fathers Lamech. <i>Genesis 5:25</i>
Age 369	●	Grandfather of Noah Lamech fathers Noah at 182, naming him in hope of comfort from the cursed ground. <i>Genesis 5:28-29 (age by calculation)</i>
The next 782 years	●	Raises a family Methuselah fathers sons and daughters. <i>Genesis 5:26</i>
Age 969	●	Dies "All the days of Methuselah were nine hundred sixty and nine years: and he died." <i>Genesis 5:27</i>

Group notes

Key activities

A popular teaching says Methuselah's name means "when he dies, it shall be sent," pointing to the flood. This is not certain and is not stated in Scripture. The link between his death and the flood year comes only from adding up the ages in Genesis 5 ($187 + 182 + 600 = 969$).

- 1 **Was raised by a man who walked with God.** Genesis says his father Enoch walked with God for 300 years after Methuselah was born.
Genesis 5:21-22
- 2 **Fathered Lamech.** Through Lamech, the line continued to Noah.
Genesis 5:25, 28-29
- 3 **Raised a large family.** He fathered other sons and daughters. *Genesis 5:26*
- 4 **Lived 969 years.** No one in Scripture is recorded as living longer.
Genesis 5:27

Group notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines, typical of notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Methuselah.

Old Testament

Genesis 5:21–27	This is the whole account.
1 Chronicles 1:3	He is listed in the line "Enoch, Methuselah, Lamech."
Echoes	Human lifespans shorten after the flood (Genesis 11:10–32). Moses writes, "So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom" (Psalm 90:12).

New Testament

Luke 3:37	He appears as "Mathusala" in the genealogy of Jesus.
Echoes	"One day is with the Lord as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day" (2 Peter 3:8).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What two things does Genesis tell us about Methuselah's life besides his age (Genesis 5:25–26)?
2. *Understand:* Methuselah lived between Enoch and Noah. What might he have learned from his father, and passed on to his grandson?
3. *Apply:* Psalm 90:12 asks God to teach us to number our days. How would you live differently if you counted your days?
4. *Apply:* What legacy of faith do you hope to leave, whether your life is long or short?